

Indian Art & Culture

One Shot Revision



Overview and Key Concepts

What is Art & Culture?

- **Art** – creative expression of beauty, ideas and beliefs.
- **Culture** – way of life of a society, including its customs, traditions, language, art forms and values.



Types of Cultural Heritage

Tangible Heritage

- Monuments
- Buildings
- Sculptures
- Manuscripts
- Artifacts

Intangible Heritage

- Traditions
- Performing arts
- Festivals
- Oral traditions
- Languages



Key Features

- Rich and diverse
- Continuous evolution
- Blend of multiple traditions
- Regional variations
- Unity in diversity
- Reflected in daily life
- Influenced by religion, nature, and social structure.



Major Art Forms



Architecture



Sculpture



Painting



Music



Dance



Drama & Theatre



Literature



Handicrafts & Crafts



Festivals & Fairs



Cuisine & Lifestyle



INDIAN ART & CULTURE



Why Important?

- Shows the identity of India.
- Reflects social and religious life.
- Preserves traditions and knowledge.
- Attracts global recognition.
- Represents India's unity in diversity.
- Important source for understanding history and society.



Sources to Study Art & Culture

- Archaeological remains
- Inscriptions
- Literary texts (Vedas, Epics, Puranas, Buddhist & Jain texts, etc.)
- Travellers' accounts
- Coins
- Art and architectural monuments
- Folk traditions and oral sources



Major Historical Periods

Prehistoric & Early Cultures

- Stone Age cultures
- Megalithic cultures



Indus Valley Civilization

- Urban culture
- Art and crafts
- Town planning



Vedic Period

- Early and Later Vedic culture
- Rituals and literature



Mahajanapada to Mauryan

- Buddhist & Jain art
- Mauryan art and architecture



Post-Mauryan to Gupta

- Sculpture schools
- Caves and temples
- Golden age of art and culture



Post-Gupta to Medieval

- Temple architecture
- Regional styles
- Bhakti-Sufi traditions
- Painting traditions



Modern Period

- Continuation of traditions
- New art forms
- Cultural reforms
- National identity



Prehistoric & Indus Valley

Art and Craft Traditions



Prehistoric Art

- Earliest artistic expression by human beings.
- Found in rock shelters and caves.
- Mainly rock paintings.
- Shows scenes of hunting, animals, daily life and symbolic figures.
- Major sites: Bhimbetka, Kurnool Caves, Adamgarh.



Bhimbetka Rock Painting



Features of Prehistoric Art

- Drawn on cave walls and rock shelters.
- Used natural colours (red, white, black, yellow).
- Depicts animals (bison, deer, elephant), hunting scenes and human figures.
- Simple and symbolic style.
- Important for understanding early human life.



Major Forms of Harappan Art



Sculpture



Seals



Pottery



Terracotta Figures



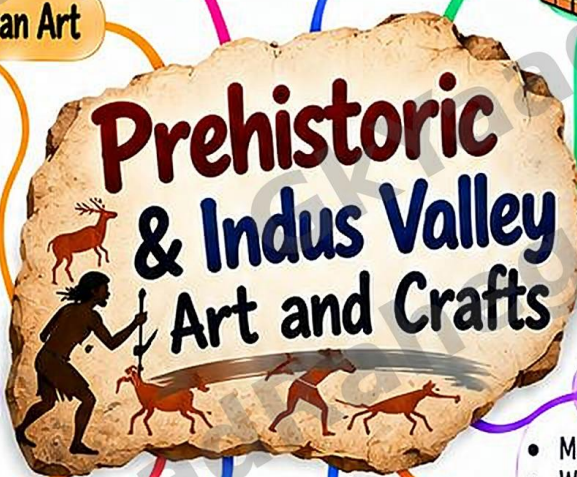
Beads and Ornaments



Metal Objects



Town Planning



Indus Valley Civilization (Art and Craft Features)

- Highly developed urban art and crafts.
- Standardised and well-planned.
- Use of natural and durable materials.
- Both utilitarian (daily use) and non-utilitarian (artistic) objects.
- Shows advanced technical skills and aesthetic sense.



Pottery

- Made of baked clay.
- Well-fired, fine and wheel-made.
- Decorated with geometric designs (lines, circles, triangles) and sometimes animal motifs.
- Red ware with black designs was common.



Harappan Pottery



Terracotta Figures

- Mostly female figurines (mother goddess).
- Animal figurines (bull, dog, bird, etc.).
- Used for religious, domestic or decorative purposes.

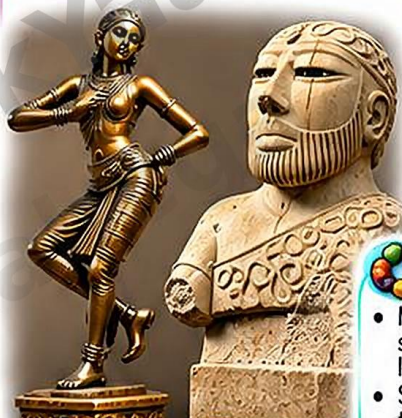


Terracotta Bull



Sculptures

- Famous example: Dancing Girl (bronze).
- Priest-King (steatite).
- Realistic and natural style.
- Shows advanced metal casting and sculpting skills.



Dancing Girl (Bronze)

Priest-King (Steatite)



Seals

- Mostly made of steatite.
- Square or rectangular in shape.
- Carved with animals and short inscriptions.
- Used for trade and administration.
- Common motifs: Unicorn (most common), bull, elephant, rhinoceros, tiger, composite animals.



Unicorn Seal (Most common motif)



Beads and Ornaments

- Made from semi-precious stones like carnelian, agate, lapis lazuli, faience.
- Show advanced bead-making techniques.



Harappan Beads



Metal Objects

- Use of copper, bronze, gold and silver.
- Objects: tools, weapons, ornaments, mirrors and figurines.
- Show metallurgical skills.



Bronze Bull



Town Planning and Architecture

- Well-planned cities with standardised bricks.
- Granaries, reservoirs, drains, public baths.
- Examples: Harappa, Mohenjodaro, Dholavira, Lothal.



Great Bath (Mohenjodaro)

Vedic Age Art and Culture

Life, Literature, Society and Material Culture



Vedic Literature

- Four Vedas – Rigveda, Samaveda, Yajurveda, Atharvaveda.
- Early texts composed in Vedic Sanskrit.
- Mainly oral tradition.
- Other texts – Brahmanas, Aranyakas, Upanishads.
- Vedic hymns – composed by Rishis.
- Important Rishis – Vasistha, Vishwamitra, Atri, Bharadwaja, Gautama.



Four Vedas



Religious Beliefs and Practices

- Belief in nature worship – Indra (rain), Agni (fire), Varuna (water), Surya (sun).
- Yajna (sacrificial ritual) was central.
- Later period – meditation, philosophy and Upanishadic ideas (Brahman, Atman).
- Concepts of Karma, Rebirth and Moksha developed in later Vedic period.
- Society was largely polytheistic, later moved towards monotheistic and philosophical ideas.



Yajna
(Vedic Ritual)



Settlement and Houses

- Early Vedic people – semi-nomadic, lived in simple huts.
- Houses made of wood, bamboo, thatch and mud.
- Later Vedic period – more permanent settlements in Ganga plains.
- Development of villages and towns; use of fortified settlements.



Vedic House (Reconstruction)



Vedic Age Art and Culture



Economy and Crafts

- Main occupation – agriculture and animal husbandry.
- Important crops – wheat, barley, rice (later period).
- Use of iron (later Vedic period) led to expansion of agriculture.
- Cattle (especially cow) was main wealth.
- Crafts – pottery, chariot-making, metal work, jewellery and textile production.



Vedic Pottery



Ornaments



Performing Arts

- Music – important part of Vedic rituals.
- Sama Veda contains musical hymns.
- Use of musical instruments like Veena, Dundaubhi, Vamsha (flute).
- Dance and songs were performed on social and religious occasions.
- Recitation of hymns followed specific intonation and melody.



Veena

Dundaubhi
(Drum)



Vamsha
(Flute)



Material Culture

- Use of copper, bronze and later iron.
- Pottery – mainly black and red ware.
- Ornaments – gold, silver, copper, beads and semi-precious stones.
- Weapons – bow, arrow, spear, sword and chariot.
- Use of chariots in warfare.



Black and Red Ware
Pottery

Vedic Chariot



Social and Cultural Life

- Varna system – Brahmana, Kshatriya, Vaishya, Shudra.
- Position of women was relatively better in early Vedic period.
- Major festivals – linked to seasons and agricultural cycle.
- Simple way of life, close to nature.
- Literature, rituals, music and nature worship formed the core of Vedic culture.



Monuments, Sculpture and Key Features



Buddhism – Origin and Patronage

- Founded by **Gautama Buddha** (6th century BCE).
- Early monuments built by **Mauryas, Shungas, Satavahanas** and **Kushanas**.
- Buddhist art evolved from **aniconic** to **iconic** representation.
- Spread to India and other countries through missionaries and trade.



Sanchi Stupa
(Madhya Pradesh)



Architectural Forms (Buddhist)

Stupa



- Dome-shaped structure.
- Houses relics.
- Example: Sanchi, Bharhut, Amaravati.

Chaitya



- Prayer hall with stupa.
- Arched entrance.
- Example: Karla, Bhaja, Ajanta.

Vihara



- Monasteries for monks.
- Residential cells and halls.
- Example: Ajanta, Nalanda.



Major Buddhist Sites



Sanchi (MP) Great stupa, torana



Bharhut (MP) Stupa, railings



Amaravati (AP) Sculptures, stupa



Karla (MH) Chaitya



Ajanta (MH) Cave paintings



Nalanda (Bihar) Mahavihara (university)



Buddhist and Jain Art & Architecture



Buddhist Sculpture

Aniconic Phase



- Buddha not shown in human form.
- Symbols used – lotus, Bodhi tree, wheel, footprints, stupa, empty throne.

Iconic Phase



- Human form of Buddha.
- Influenced by Gandhara and Mathura schools.
- Common features – ushnisha, urna, long earlobes, dhyana mudra.



Jainism – Origin and Patronage

- Founded by **Rishabhanatha** (1st Tirthankara).
- 24 Tirthankaras – last was Mahavira (6th century BCE).
- Important patrons – Mauryas, Guptas, Rashtrakutas, Hoysalas, Chalukyas.
- Emphasis on non-violence and asceticism.



Jain Tirthankara
(Shravanabelagola)



Dilwara Temple
(Mount Abu)



Major Jain Sites



Shravanabelagola (Karnataka) Gomateshwara statue (Bahubali)



Dilwara (Rajasthan) Famous Jain temples



Ranakpur (Rajasthan) Chaumukha temple



Khandagiri-Udayagiri (Odisha) Jain caves



Sonagiri (MP) Jain temples



Girnar (Gujarat) Important Jain site



Features of Jain Art and Architecture

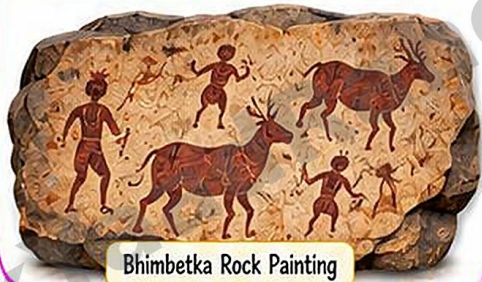
- Tirthankara images in meditative posture (padmasana or khadgasana).
- Symbols used – lion, bull, conch, snake associated with different Tirthankaras.
- Highly ornate temples with intricate carvings.
- Use of white marble in Dilwara temples.
- Rock-cut caves at Khandagiri-Udayagiri.
- Famous statue – Gomateshwara (Bahubali) at Shravanabelagola (57 feet).





Ancient Painting Traditions

- Earliest paintings found in Bhimbetka (prehistoric rock paintings).
- Themes – animals, hunting scenes and human figures.
- Important later examples – Ajanta, Bagh and Sittanavasal.
- Natural colours and fine artistic skills.

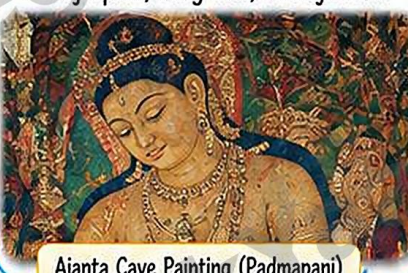


Bhimbetka Rock Painting



Ajanta Paintings

- Located in Maharashtra.
- Related to Buddhism.
- Depicts Jataka tales, Buddha's life and contemporary society.
- Use of natural colours, shading and realistic expressions.
- Famous examples – Padmapani, Vajrapani, King Sibi, Mahajanaka.



Ajanta Cave Painting (Padmapani)



Bagh Paintings

- Located in Madhya Pradesh.
- Similar to Ajanta in style.
- Themes – Buddhist subjects, royal life and daily scenes.
- Use of bold lines and rich colours.



Bagh Cave Painting



Sittanavasal Paintings

- Located in Tamil Nadu.
- Jain paintings.
- Depicts lotus pond, dancers and animals.
- Use of vibrant colours.

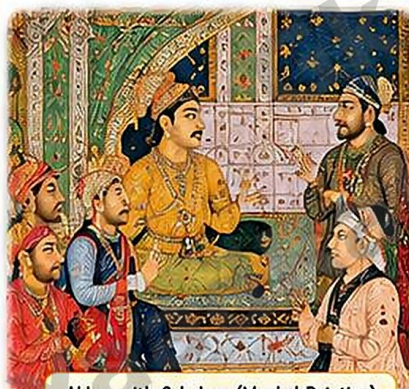


Sittanavasal (Tamil Nadu)



Mughal Paintings

- Began under Humayun, flourished under Akbar.
- Blend of Persian and Indian styles.
- Themes – court scenes, wars, nature and portraits.
- Famous painters – Daswanth, Basawan, Manohar, Ustad Mansur.
- Accurate detailing and realistic style.



Akbar with Scholars (Mughal Painting)



Indian Painting Traditions



Rajput Paintings

- Developed in Rajasthan and other regions.
- Themes – Hindu epics (Ramayana, Mahabharata), love stories and nature.
- Important styles – Mewar, Marwar, Bundi and Kota.
- Bold colours and strong expression.



Pahari Paintings

- Developed in Himalayan regions (Jammu & Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh).
- Themes – Krishna-Radha, nature, Bhakti and romance.
- Soft colours and delicate lines.
- Important styles – Basohli, Guler, Kangra.



Radha-Krishna (Pahari Style)



Deccani Paintings

- Developed in Deccan region (Ahmadnagar, Bijapur, Golconda, Hyderabad).
- Blend of Persian and Indian styles.
- Themes – royal life, Sufi influence, nature and women.
- Use of rich colours and unique features (large eyes, elongated figures).



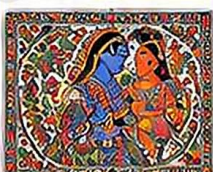
Deccani Painting



Folk and Tribal Painting Traditions

Madhubani

- Bihar
- Themes – nature, God-Goddess
- Use of natural colours



Madhubani Painting

Warli

- Maharashtra
- Simple geometric figures
- Depicts daily life and nature



Warli Painting

Pattachitra

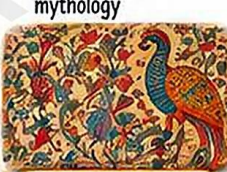
- Odisha
- Themes – Jagannath, Hindu mythology
- Use of natural colours



Pattachitra Painting

Kalamkari

- Andhra Pradesh
- Hand-painted or block-printed
- Themes – epics, mythology



Kalamkari Painting

Gond

- Madhya Pradesh
- Use of dots and lines
- Themes – animals, nature, folklore



Gond Painting

Phad

- Rajasthan
- Narrative style
- Depicts folk deities like Pabuji, Devnarayan



Phad Painting

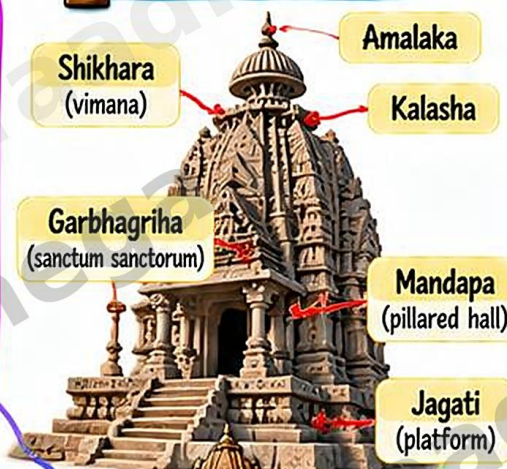


What is a Temple?

- Temple – a sacred structure used for worship.
- Reflects India's religious, cultural and artistic traditions.
- Developed into distinct regional styles over time.
- Shows influence of dynasties, religion and local traditions.



Parts of a Temple



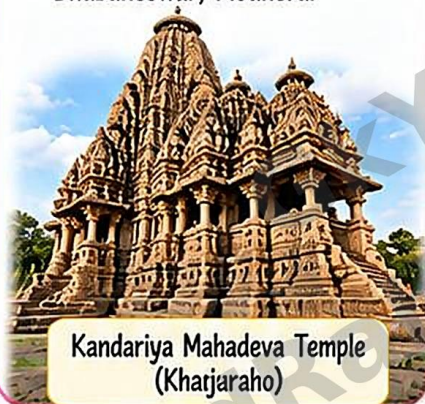
Common Features

- Garbhagriha – main shrine.
- Shikhara (Nagara) / Vimana (Dravida).
- Mandapa – pillared hall.
- Amalaka and Kalasha (Nagara).
- Use of sculptures and carvings.
- Depicts religious stories, deities and mythology.
- Built with stone, brick or a combination.
- Regional variations in style and decorations.



Nagara Style (North India)

- Common in North India.
- Curvilinear Shikhara.
- Square or rectangular base.
- Amalaka and Kalasha at top.
- Rich sculptural decoration.
- Examples – Khajuraho, Konark, Bhubaneswar, Modhera.



Major Styles of Indian Temple Architecture



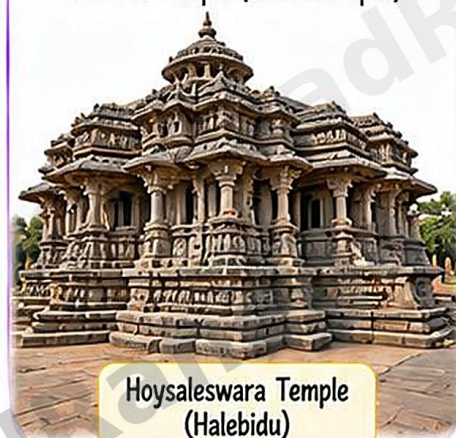
Dravida Style (South India)

- Common in South India.
- Pyramidal Vimana (tiered).
- Enclosed by high compound walls.
- Gopuram at entrance.
- Mandapas and huge temple complexes.
- Examples – Brihadeeswara (Thanjavur), Meenakshi (Madurai), Shore Temple (Mahabalipuram).



Vesara Style (Deccan Region)

- A blend of Nagara and Dravida styles.
- Common in Deccan region.
- Shows features of both styles.
- Examples – Hoysaleswara (Halebidu), Chennakesava (Belur), Keshava Temple (Somanathapur).



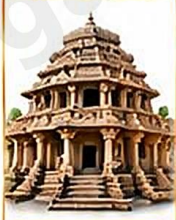
Other Important Temple Types

Kalinga Style (Odisha)



Lingaraja Temple (Bhubaneswar)

Mara-Gurjara (Western India)



Sun Temple (Modhera)

Chalukyan (Karnataka)



Virupaksha Temple (Pattadakal)

Pallava (Tamil Nadu)



Shore Temple (Mahabalipuram)



Important Examples (Style-wise)

Temple	Location	Style	Patron/Dynasty
Kandariya Mahadeva	Khajuraho (MP)	Nagara	Chandela
Konark Sun Temple	Konark (Odisha)	Kalinga (Nagara variant)	Ganga
Brihadeeswara	Thanjavur (TN)	Dravida	Rajaraja I (Chola)
Meenakshi Temple	Madurai (TN)	Dravida	Nayaks
Hoysaleswara	Halebidu (Karnataka)	Vesara	Hoysala
Shore Temple	Mahabalipuram (TN)	Dravida	Pallava
Lingaraja Temple	Bhubaneswar (Odisha)	Kalinga	Somavamsi
Virupaksha Temple	Pattadakal (Karnataka)	Chalukyan	Chalukya

Major Schools, Styles and Important Examples



Features of Indian Sculpture

- Developed with religious, cultural and artistic motives.
- Depicts deities, human figures, animals and scenes from epics.
- Use of stone, bronze, terracotta and wood.
- Reflects regional styles and influence of rulers and religions.
- Highly symbolic with spiritual significance.



Nataraja
(Chola Period)



Indus Valley Sculpture

- Mainly terracotta figurines and animal figures.
- Famous example – Dancing Girl (bronze).
- Priest-King (steatite).
- Simple and realistic style.
- Shows knowledge of metal casting and fine craftsmanship.



Priest-King
(Harappan)

Dancing Girl
(Harappan)



Lion Capital of Sarnath
(Mauryan)

Mauryan Sculpture

- Polished sandstone.
- Realistic and grand style.
- Major examples – Ashoka pillars, Lion Capital of Sarnath.
- Shows influence of Achaemenid art but with Indian elements.



Gandhara School

- Flourished in north-west India.
- Influenced by Greek and Roman art.
- Use of grey schist stone.
- Realistic and natural style with drapery like Greek sculptures.
- Main subject – Buddha.



Seated Buddha
(Gandhara Style)



Standing Buddha
(Mathura Style)



Mathura School

- Flourished in Mathura (Uttar Pradesh).
- Use of red sandstone.
- Indigenous Indian style.
- Robust and spiritual expression.
- Figures of Buddha, Jain Tirthankaras and Hindu deities.



Amaravati School

- Flourished in Andhra region.
- Use of white limestone.
- Fine and delicate carvings.
- Main subject – Buddhist sculptures (stupa panels).



Stupa Panel
(Amaravati Style)



Chola Bronze Sculpture

- Flourished in Tamil Nadu.
- Made of bronze using lost-wax technique (Dhokra method).
- Dynamic, graceful and highly artistic style.
- Famous example – Nataraja (Shiva), Parvati, Subrahmanya.



Nataraja
(Chola Bronze)



Major Schools at a Glance

School	Region	Material Used	Main Features	Important Examples
Indus Valley	Harappan region	Terracotta, bronze, steatite	Simple, realistic, early craft	Dancing Girl, Priest-King
Mauryan	Pan-India	Polished sandstone	Grandeur, realism	Lion Capital of Sarnath
Gandhara	North-west India	Grey schist	Greek influence, natural style	Buddha statues
Mathura	Mathura (UP)	Red sandstone	Indian style, robust	Buddha, Jain Tirthankaras
Amaravati	Andhra region	White limestone	Delicate carvings, Buddhist	Stupa panels
Chola	Tamil Nadu	Bronze	Dynamic, graceful, lost-wax	Nataraja, Parvati

Classical Music, Instruments and Folk Traditions



Hindustani vs Carnatic Music

Feature	Hindustani Music	Carnatic Music
Region	North India	South India
Origin	Blend of ancient, folk, Persian and Islamic influences	Rooted in ancient traditions, less outside influence
Language	Mainly Hindi, Urdu, Braj, Persian	Mainly Sanskrit, Telugu, Tamil, Kannada
Style	More improvisation (alaap, khayal prominent)	More structured (composition-centric)
Important forms	Dhrupad, Khayal, Thumri, Tappa	Kriti, Varnam, Keertana
Main exponents	Tansen, Bismillah Khan, Bhimsen Joshi	Tyagaraja, Muthuswami Dikshitar, Syama Sastri



Raga and Tala

- Raga** – melodic framework with specific notes (swaras), mood and time of performance. Ex: Bhairav, Yaman, Todi.
- Tala** – rhythmic cycle of beats. Ex: Teentaal (16 beats), Ektaal (12), Jhaptaal (10), Rupak (7), Adi Tala (8).



Raga (bhava + swara)



Tala (rhythmic cycle)



Gharanas (Hindustani Music)

- Gharana** – a distinct school of music with unique style and tradition.
- Important Gharanas:

Gharana	Associated With
Gwalior	Khayal (oldest)
Agra	Dhrupad, Khayal
Jaipur-Atrauli	Complex ragas
Kirana	Swara and melody
Patiala	Fast tempo, taans
Rampur-Sahaswan	Khayal, instrumental
Benares	Thumri, Dadra



Classification of Musical Instruments

- Indian instruments are classified into 4 groups (Tatat, Sushir, Avanaddha, Ghana) as per Bharata's Natyashastra.

Tatat (String Instruments)	Sushir (Wind Instruments)	Avanaddha (Percussion Instruments)	Ghana (Solid Instruments)
Sitar, Veena, Sarod	Bansuri, Shehnai, Nadaswaram	Tabla, Mridangam, Pakhawaj	Manjira, Kartal, Ghatam



Important Musicians



Tansen

- Navaratna of Akbar.
- Dhrupad singer.
- Associated with Gwalior gharana.



Purandara Dasa

- Father of Carnatic music.
- Compositions in Kannada.
- Simplified music education.



Tyagaraja

- Famous Carnatic composer.
- Compositions in Telugu.
- Devotion to Lord Rama.



Bhimsen Joshi

- Kirana gharana.
- Famous for Khayal.
- Bharat Ratna awardee.



M. S. Subbulakshmi

- Renowned Carnatic vocalist.
- First musician to receive Bharat Ratna.



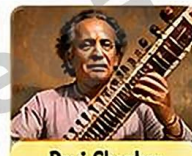
Bismillah Khan

- Legendary shehnai player.
- Associated with Benares gharana.



Kumar Gandharva

- Known for innovation in classical music.
- Revived many rare ragas.



Ravi Shankar

- World-famous sitar player.
- Popularised Indian music globally.



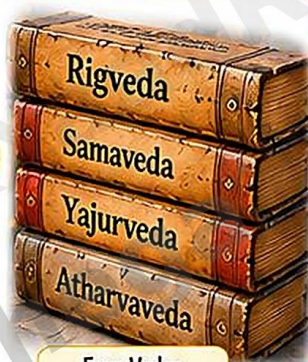
Folk and Traditional Performing Arts

Yakshagana	Jatra	Nautanki	Tamasha	Bhavai
Karnataka	West Bengal	Uttar Pradesh	Maharashtra	Gujarat
- Combination of dance, music, dialogue and costume. - Depicts episodes from epics.	- Popular folk theatre form. - Themes – mythological, social and political. - Use of music, dance and dialogue.	- Folk theatre form with music and song. - Popular themes – romance, bravery and social issues. - Known for dramatic style and simple language.	- Folk dance-theatre form. - Use of music, dance, humour and satire. - Themes – social and political issues.	- Traditional folk theatre. - Use of dance, music, comedy and satire. - Performs on social evils and local issues.
Yakshagana	Jatra	Nautanki	Tamasha	Bhavai



Vedas

- Earliest religious literature in Sanskrit.
- Composed in Vedic period.
- Four Vedas – Rigveda, Samaveda, Yajurveda, Atharvaveda.
- Contain hymns (suktas), rituals and philosophical ideas.
- Brahmanas, Aranyakas and Upanishads are parts of Vedic literature.

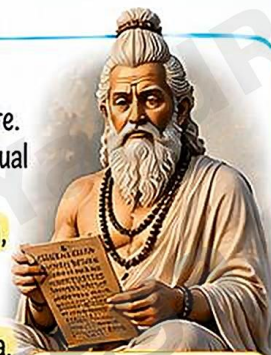


Four Vedas



Upanishads

- Concluding part of Vedic literature.
- Deal with philosophical and spiritual ideas.
- Key concepts – Brahman, Atman, Karma, Rebirth and Moksha.
- Important Upanishads – Isha, Kena, Katha, Mundaka, Mandukya, Chandogya and Brihadaranyaka.



Sage (depicting Upanishadic tradition)



Epics

- Ramayana – attributed to Valmiki.
- Mahabharata – attributed to Vyasa.
- Contain moral, social and political teachings.
- Important texts – Bhagavad Gita (part of Mahabharata).



Ramayana (Valmiki)

Mahabharata (Vyasa)



Puranas

- Contain mythological stories, genealogies, cosmology and religious teachings.
- 18 Mahapuranas – Brahma, Vishnu, Shiva, Markandeya, Bhagavata etc.
- Helped in spread of Hindu religious and cultural ideas.



Puranas (Mythological Texts)



Major Languages of Ancient India

Sanskrit

- Classical language of ancient India.
- Used in Vedas, epics, Puranas and many philosophical texts.
- Important authors – Valmiki, Vyasa, Kalidasa, Panini.



Sanskrit Manuscript

Pali

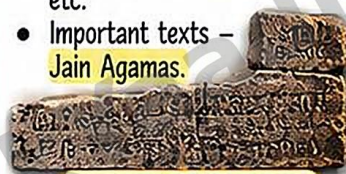
- Language of Buddhist literature.
- Used in Tripitaka.
- Associated with Buddhism.
- Important text – Tipitaka.



Pali Text (Tripitaka)

Prakrit

- Popular language of common people.
- Used in Jain and Buddhist literature.
- Types – Shauraseni, Maharashtri, Magadhi etc.
- Important texts – Jain Agamas.



Prakrit Inscription

Tamil

- Major classical language of South India.
- Rich literary tradition (Sangam literature).
- Early Tamil texts – Ettuthokai and Pathuppattu.
- Important works – Tolkappiyam (grammar).



Tamil Inscription



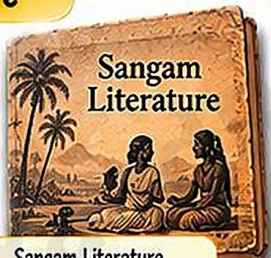
Important Authors and Texts

Author	Text	Language	Key Contribution
Valmiki	Ramayana	Sanskrit	Epic on Rama
Vyasa	Mahabharata	Sanskrit	Epic, Bhagavad Gita
Panini	Ashtadhyayi	Sanskrit	Grammar
Kalidasa	Abhijnanashakuntalam	Sanskrit	Famous playwright
Ashvaghosha	Buddhacharita	Sanskrit	Life of Buddha
Bana Bhatta	Harshacharita	Sanskrit	Biography of Harshavardhana
Ilango Adigal	Silappadikaram	Tamil	Tamil epic
Thiruvalluvar	Tirukkural	Tamil	Ethical teachings



Sangam Literature

- Composed in early historic period in Tamil.
- Divided into – Ettuthokai (Eight Anthologies) and Pathuppattu (Ten Idylls).
- Themes – love (akam), war (puram), nature and society.
- Important works – Purananuru, Akananuru, Kuruntokai.



Sangam Literature (Tamil)

Saints, Teachings and Regional Associations



Bhakti Movement – Overview

- A devotional movement that emphasised love and devotion to a personal God.
- Opposed ritualism, caste discrimination and religious orthodoxy.
- Spread in both North and South India.
- Major streams – Nirguna (without form) and Saguna (with form).



Alvars (South India)

- 12 Alvars – Vaishnava saints of Tamil Nadu.
- Composed devotional hymns in Tamil (Divya Prabandham).
- Emphasised devotion to Vishnu.
- Helped in spread of Bhakti movement in South India.



Alvar Saint
(Tamil Nadu)



Nayanars (South India)

- 63 Nayanars – Shaiva saints of Tamil Nadu.
- Composed hymns in devotion of Shiva (Tevaram).
- Belonged to different castes and professions.
- Key saints – Appar, Sambandar, Sundarar.



Nayanar Saint
(Shiva Bhakti)



Important Bhakti Saints (North India)



Kabir

- Nirguna Bhakti.
- Opposed caste system and ritualism.
- Composition – Sakhis and Dohas.



Mirabai

- Devotion to Krishna.
- Composed bhajans in Rajasthani.
- Symbol of love, devotion and surrender.



Tulsidas

- Famous for Ramcharitmanas (in Awadhi).
- Major work – Ramcharitmanas.
- Devotion to Lord Rama.



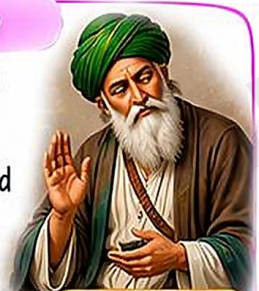
Guru Nanak

- Founder of Sikhism.
- Emphasised one God, equality and service to humanity.
- Major texts – Japji Sahib.



Sufi Movement – Overview

- A spiritual movement within Islam emphasising love, compassion and devotion to God.
- Influenced by Islamic teachings and local Indian traditions.
- Used simple language and music to spread their message.
- Important Sufi orders – Chishti, Suhrawardi, Qadiri and Naqshbandi.



Sufi Saint
(Chishti Order)



Important Sufi Orders

Order	Founder	Main Features	Important Centre
Chishti	Moinuddin Chishti	Love, tolerance, service to humanity	Ajmer
Suhrawardi	Shihabuddin Suhrawardi	Closer to rulers, more organised	Multan
Qadiri	Abdul Qadir Jilani	Spiritual teachings	Baghdad (influence in India)
Naqshbandi	Bahauddin Naqshband	Strict discipline, Sharia based	Central Asia (later in India)



Other Important Saints and their Associations

Saint	Tradition	Region	Key Teachings / Works
Ramananda	Bhakti (Vaishnava)	North India	Popularised Bhakti in North India; disciples included Kabir.
Surdas	Bhakti (Vaishnava)	Braj	Devotion to Krishna; Sursagar.
Chaitanya Mahaprabhu	Bhakti (Vaishnava)	Bengal	Gaudiya Vaishnavism; Kirtan tradition.
Eknath	Bhakti	Maharashtra	Writings in Marathi; equality and devotion.
Namdev	Bhakti	Maharashtra	Abhangas; devotion to Vitthal.
Basavanna	Bhakti (Virashaiva)	Karnataka	Social reform; Vachanas.
Lalleshwari (Lal Ded)	Bhakti (Shaiva)	Kashmir	Mystic poems (Vakhs).
Shankaradeva	Bhakti (Vaishnava)	Assam	Neo-Vaishnavism; Borgeet and Ankiya Naat.



Key Features and Impact

- Promoted social harmony and equality.
- Used local languages for wider reach.
- Influenced art, literature, music and culture.
- Helped in the development of regional languages.
- Laid the foundation for a composite Indian culture.
- Their teachings are still relevant for social reform and unity.



Ektara
(Bhakti Tradition)



Qawwali
(Sufi Tradition)



Major Regional Festivals, Fairs and Traditions of India



Importance of Festivals and Fairs

- Reflect India's cultural diversity and unity.
- Associated with religious, social, seasonal and agricultural cycles.
- Promote art, music, dance, crafts and local economy.
- Attract tourists and provide livelihood to many people.
- Strengthen social bonds and preserve traditions.



Major Religious Festivals

Festival	Associated With
Diwali	Victory of light over darkness (Rama, Krishna, regional beliefs)
Holi	Festival of colours, associated with Krishna
Dussehra	Victory of good over evil (Rama and Ravana)
Navratri	Worship of Goddess Durga (nine forms)
Janmashtami	Birth of Lord Krishna
Ganesh Chaturthi	Worship of Lord Ganesha
Maha Shivratri	Worship of Lord Shiva



Major Regional Festivals

Region / State	Festival	Key Features
Punjab	Baisakhi	Harvest festival, new year (Sikh tradition)
Assam	Bihu	Rongali Bihu, agricultural festival with dance and music
West Bengal	Durga Puja	Worship of Goddess Durga, grand celebrations
Tamil Nadu	Pongal	Harvest festival, thanks to Sun God
Kerala	Onam	Associated with King Mahabali, boat races, floral decorations
Gujarat	Navratri (Garba)	Dance festival dedicated to Goddess Durga
Rajasthan	Teej	Monsoon festival, women's festival
Kashmir	Hemis	Buddhist festival, colourful processions



Important Fairs (Melas)

- Fairs are temporary gatherings held for religious, social, cultural and economic purposes.
- They provide a platform for trade, cultural exchange and tourism.
- Many fairs are associated with specific deities, rivers or events.



Kumbh Mela
(Prayagraj)



Pushkar Fair
(Rajasthan)



Rath Yatra
(Puri, Odisha)



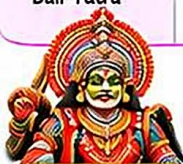
Other Important Fairs

Fair	Location	Associated With
Kumbh Mela	Prayagraj, Haridwar, Ujjain, Nashik	Holy rivers, mass congregation (largest fair)
Pushkar Fair	Pushkar (Rajasthan)	Cattle fair, Lord Brahma
Sonepur Mela	Sonepur (Bihar)	Asia's largest cattle fair (Ganga-Gandak confluence)
Tarnetar Fair	Tarnetar (Gujarat)	Marriage fair, tribal traditions
Surajkund Mela	Faridabad (Haryana)	Crafts, handlooms and cultural performances
Hemis Fair	Ladakh	Buddhist festival, mask dance
Bali Yatra	Cuttack (Odisha)	Ancient maritime trade tradition



Cultural Traditions and Folk Performances

Art Form	State / Region	Key Features
Yakshagana	Karnataka	Dance, music, dialogue and elaborate costumes
Jatra	West Bengal	Popular folk theatre form
Nautanki	Uttar Pradesh	Folk theatre with music and song
Tamasha	Maharashtra	Folk dance-theatre with humour and music
Bhavai	Gujarat	Folk theatre, social satire
Kathakali	Kerala	Classical dance-drama with makeup and costumes
Bhangra	Punjab	Folk dance, harvest festival (Baisakhi)
Ghoomar	Rajasthan	Traditional women's dance



Yakshagana
(Karnataka)



Jatra
(West Bengal)



Nautanki
(Uttar Pradesh)



Tamasha
(Maharashtra)



Bhavai
(Gujarat)



Kathakali
(Kerala)



Bhangra
(Punjab)

Classical, Folk and Traditional Performing Arts



Classical Dances of India

- India has 8 Classical Dances recognised by Sangeet Natak Akademi.
- Based on Natya Shastra.
- Depict religious, mythological and social themes.
- Characterised by specific mudras, costumes, music and regional styles.



Bharatanatyam
(Tamil Nadu)



List of 8 Classical Dances

Dance Form	State / Region	Key Features
Bharatanatyam	Tamil Nadu	Oldest classical dance, expressions and mudras
Kathak	North India (Uttar Pradesh)	Storytelling, fast footwork, spins (chakkars)
Kathakali	Kerala	Elaborate makeup, costumes, mythological themes
Kuchipudi	Andhra Pradesh	Dance-drama, graceful movements
Odissi	Odisha	Sculptural poses, temples of Konark influence
Manipuri	Manipur	Graceful, devotional dance (associated with Vaishnavism)
Mohiniyattam	Kerala	Feminine style, gentle movements
Sattriya	Assam	Based on Vaishnavite tradition of Srimanta Sankardeva



Important Folk Dances

Dance Form	State / Region	Key Features
Bhangra	Punjab	Harvest dance, energetic movements
Giddha	Punjab	Folk dance of women
Garba	Gujarat	Performed during Navratri
Dandiya	Gujarat	Stick dance, Navratri festival
Ghoomar	Rajasthan	Traditional women's dance
Lavani	Maharashtra	Fast rhythm, expressive movements
Bihu	Assam	Harvest festival dance
Chhau	Odisha, Jharkhand, West Bengal	Martial dance, masks and vibrant costumes



Important Dance-Drama Traditions

- Combines dance, music, dialogue and acting.
- Based on mythological and religious stories.
- Uses elaborate costumes, masks and make-up.
- Popular in many regions with distinct styles.



Yakshagana
(Karnataka)

Kathakali
(Kerala)



Major Traditional & Regional Performing Arts

Art Form	State / Region	Key Features
Yakshagana	Karnataka	Dance, music, dialogue, elaborate costumes
Jatra	West Bengal	Popular folk theatre form
Nautanki	Uttar Pradesh	Folk theatre with music and song
Tamasha	Maharashtra	Folk dance-theatre with humour and music
Bhava	Gujarat	Folk theatre, social satire
Kathakali	Kerala	Classical dance-drama with makeup and costumes
Swang	Haryana	Folk theatre form
Therukoothu	Tamil Nadu	Street theatre, mythological themes
Ramlila	North India	Enactment of Ramayana
Rasleela	Uttar Pradesh (Braj region)	Depicts life of Krishna



Famous Instruments in Performing Arts

Instrument	Type	Used In
Tabla	Percussion	Hindustani Classical, Folk
Mridangam	Percussion	Carnatic Classical
Pakhawaj	Percussion	Dhrupad, Classical
Harmonium	Keyboard	Classical, Folk, Theatre
Sitar	String	Hindustani Classical
Veena	String	Carnatic Classical
Flute	Wind	Both Classical Traditions
Shehnai	Wind	Classical, Folk, Ceremonial
Dhol	Percussion	Folk Dances (Bhangra etc.)
Nagara	Percussion	Traditional & Folk Performances



Famous Theatre Traditions

Tradition	Region	Features
Jatra	West Bengal	Folk theatre, social and political themes
Nautanki	Uttar Pradesh	Music, song and dialogue
Tamasha	Maharashtra	Humour, dance and music
Bhava	Gujarat	Social satire
Swang	Haryana	Folk dramatic performances
Ramlila	North India	Enactment of Ramayana
Rasleela	Braj (Uttar Pradesh)	Life of Krishna



Tabla



Mridangam



Sitar



Flute

Music, Dance, Theatre and Folk Traditions – Key Personalities and Institutions



Important Indian Musicians

Musician	Associated With	Key Contribution
Tansen	Hindustani Classical	Navaratna of Akbar; famous ragas Miyan ki Todi, Miyan ki Malhar
Purandara Dasa	Carnatic Classical	Father of Carnatic music; composed thousands of kritis
Tyagaraja	Carnatic Classical	Composed kritis on Lord Rama
Muthuswami Dikshitar	Carnatic Classical	Composed kritis on various deities; used Sanskrit
Syama Sastri	Carnatic Classical	Known for devotional compositions
Baiju Bawra	Hindustani Classical	Legendary musician associated with Akbar's court
Swati Tirunal	Both (Hindustani & Carnatic)	Composed in multiple languages
Kumar Gandharva	Hindustani Classical	Known for unique style and revival of folk elements



Important Dance Personalities

Personality	Associated With	Contribution
Bharata Muni	Natya Shastra	Author of Natya Shastra (foundation text of performing arts)
Rukmini Devi Arundale	Bharatanatyam	Revival and global popularity of Bharatanatyam
Balasaraswati	Bharatanatyam	Known for abhinaya and devotional style
Kelucharan Mohapatra	Odissi	Revival of Odissi
Birju Maharaj	Kathak	Renowned Kathak dancer and choreographer
Sonal Mansingh	Odissi and Bharatanatyam	Promoted Indian classical dance globally
Uday Shankar	Modern Indian Dance	Pioneer of modern Indian dance



Important Performing Arts Institutions

Institution	Location	Established	Key Role
Sangeet Natak Akademi	New Delhi	1953	Apex body for performing arts (music, dance, drama)
Kalakshetra Foundation	Chennai	1936	Promotion of Bharatanatyam and Indian art & culture
Kathak Kendra	New Delhi	1964	Promotion and preservation of Kathak
Jawaharlal Nehru Manipuri Dance Academy	Imphal	1954	Development of Manipuri dance
Ustad Bismillah Khan Yuva Puraskar	National	1999	Award for young talent in performing arts



Raga and Tala – Basics

- Raga – a melodic framework with a specific set of notes and rules for composition.
- Associated with particular time, season and emotion.
- Examples: Bhairav, Yaman, Darbari, Todi, Kalyani.
- Tala – a rhythmic cycle with a fixed number of beats (matras).
- Examples: Teentaal (16), Ektaal (12), Rupak (7), Adi Tala (8 – Carnatic).



Yakshagana (Karnataka)

- A traditional dance-theatre form of Karnataka.
- Combines dance, music, dialogue and elaborate costumes.
- Based on episodes from Ramayana and Mahabharata.



Jatra (West Bengal)

- A popular folk theatre form of West Bengal.
- Known for dialogue, music and social themes.
- Performs historical, mythological and contemporary stories.



Nautanki (Uttar Pradesh)

- A folk theatre form of Uttar Pradesh.
- Known for music, song, dance and drama.
- Popular themes – love stories, social issues and folklore.



Tamasha (Maharashtra)

- A popular folk theatre form of Maharashtra.
- Combines dance, music, humour and social satire.
- Famous for Lavani dance.



Bhavai (Gujarat)

- A traditional folk theatre form of Gujarat.
- Known for social satire and humour.
- Themes include everyday life, caste system and social evils.



Key Takeaways

- India has a rich tradition of music, dance, theatre and folk performing arts.
- Each form has distinct regional styles, costumes, music and themes.
- Raga and Tala are the foundation of Indian music.
- Several legendary musicians and dancers have contributed to the preservation and global recognition of Indian performing arts.



Integration of Classical and Folk Traditions

- Classical and folk traditions influence each other.
- Folk elements are often adopted in classical performances.
- Classical forms help in preserving and promoting folk traditions.
- Examples – use of folk tunes in classical music, folk themes in classical dance productions.
- Reflects India's cultural unity in diversity.



Modern Developments and Revival

- Government and cultural institutions are actively promoting Indian performing arts.
- Festivals, academies and media have increased their visibility.
- Many traditional forms have received national and international recognition.
- Fusion and contemporary adaptations are also popular among the younger generation.
- Help in preserving heritage while keeping traditions alive in the modern era.



Important Festivals for Performing Arts

Festival	Location	Associated With	Key Features
Khajuraho Dance Festival	Madhya Pradesh	Classical Dance	Held at Khajuraho temples
Konark Dance Festival	Odisha	Classical Dance	Held at Sun Temple, Konark
Mamallapuram Dance Festival	Tamil Nadu	Classical Dance	Held at Shore Temple
Sangeet Natak Utsav	New Delhi	Music, Dance, Theatre	Organised by Sangeet Natak Akademi
Pushkar Fair	Rajasthan	Folk Music & Dance	Camel fair with folk performances
Surajkund Mela	Haryana	Folk Arts	Showcases traditional arts and crafts



National Institutions for Promotion

Institution	Location	Established	Main Role
Sangeet Natak Akademi	New Delhi	1953	Apex body for music, dance and theatre
Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts (IGNCA)	New Delhi	1985	Research, documentation and promotion of Indian arts and culture
Zonal Cultural Centres	Various regions	1985	Promotion of regional folk arts and culture
National School of Drama (NSD)	New Delhi	1959	Training and promotion of theatre arts
Kala Akademis (State level)	Various states	—	Promotion of regional performing arts



UNESCO Recognition

Art Form	Year of Recognition	Type
Koodiyattam (Kerala)	2001	Intangible Cultural Heritage
Ramlila (North India)	2005	Intangible Cultural Heritage
Chhau Dance (Odisha, Jharkhand, WB)	2010	Intangible Cultural Heritage
Kalbelia Dance (Rajasthan)	2010	Intangible Cultural Heritage
Mudiyettu (Kerala)	2010	Intangible Cultural Heritage
Sankirtana (Manipur)	2013	Intangible Cultural Heritage



Important Points to Remember

- India has a rich and diverse tradition of music, dance, theatre and folk performing arts.
- Each region has its unique style, costumes, instruments and themes.
- Classical and folk traditions complement each other.
- Performing arts reflect India's cultural, religious, social and regional diversity.
- Many forms have received global recognition.
- Institutions and festivals play a key role in their promotion and preservation.
- These art forms continue to evolve and remain an important part of India's living heritage.



Popular Performing Arts and Their States

Bharatanatyam (Tamil Nadu)	Kathak (Uttar Pradesh)	Kathakali (Kerala)	Odissi (Odisha)	Kuchipudi (Andhra Pradesh)	Manipuri (Manipur)	Mohiniyattam (Kerala)	Chhau (Odisha, Jharkhand, WB)